Someone must've phoned the Proteas bowling coach – and my good mate – Vinnie Barnes to let him know that, given there was a game the next day, I needed rescuing. This must've been about 1 a.m., and poor Vinnie, who'd been asleep, had to get out of bed. He knocked on my hotel-room door and found me with the mommy, still drinking wine and talking shit (just for the record, nothing happened between us that night). Vinnie was seriously pissed off. I tried to say that all was good, but Vinnie knew what was what. 'Look at you, Hersch, you can't even stand up *and* you're slurring. Tell this woman she must leave now!'

It was 2 a.m. before I got to sleep, and we had to get up early the next morning to be at the ground by 8 a.m. As I've mentioned, 99 per cent of the time I wake up at sunrise, but fortunately that morning I had set my alarm. There's no way I would've woken up otherwise. But wake up I did, my head spinning. I went down to breakfast, my head still hurting, and then left for the Wanderers in the team bus, feeling as green as the colour of our Proteas kit. Chapter 7 will tell you how I not only got through the match, but also managed to score 175 runs.

… and the night after the 438 game

Proteas 'fines meetings' … man, they can be *hectic*. If you get nailed, you can go from sober to a dribbling drunk in minutes. Just ask Mickey Arthur.

If you haven't heard of them before, fines meetings are a common post-game festivity among sports teams: 'fines' in the form of a drink are handed out to various team members for any real, or trumped-up, 'transgressions' they may or may not have been guilty of during the game. After our brilliant victory against Australia, it would have been a serious understatement to say that the team was in 'high spirits', which meant the fines meeting was going to be epic. As usual Mark Boucher was our Fines Master, and he meted out the punishment admirably.

As Fines Master, Mark ran the show, making up any rules he saw fit – stuff like, if you wanted to say anything, or even ask to go to the toilet, you had to put up your hand and direct your request to him. If you didn't, you had to drink. The drink was a full can of beer. The Fines Master could also put you on 'death' if he decided you'd done something particularly stupid. Or it could just be that you were unlucky – Mark could decide that you just hadn't had enough to drink yet, and you'd be on 'death'. And you really didn't want to be on 'death', which involved drinking one full can of beer